Minbar Panels

From one or two minbars attributed to Sultan Jaqmaq

Burji Mamluk, 848-55 AH / 1444-51 CE

403 - W: 45 cm; H: 14 cm 405 - W: 45 cm; H: 14.5 cm

Inv. no. 403, 405



"Ordered the construction of this blessed minbar, [our lord] the Sultan al-Malik al-Zahir Abu Sa'id Muhammad Jaqmaq, may his victory be glorified."



These two panels are among the sole surviving elements of one or possibly two minbars attributed to Sultan Jaqmaq (r. 1438-53). Both bear identical foundation inscriptions in naskh which read: "Ordered the construction of this blessed minbar, [our lord] the Sultan al-Malik al-Zahir Abu Sa'id Muhammad Jaqmaq, may his victory be glorified." Among the pair, No. 405 is distinguished by sharper calligraphic outlines and a more assured execution, suggesting either a different hand or a higher level of

craftsmanship within the same commission. Their size and content suggest they originally flanked the passage doors (abwab al-roda) on either side of a minbar, although it remains uncertain which of Jaqmaq's minbars they were part of. The sultan is known to have erected three mosques during his lifetime: one on al-Marasina St. near the mosque of Sayyida Zaynab, another in Darb al-Saʿada, and a third, no longer extant, in al-Fustat. Today, new minbars survive in the two extant mosques, making these panels a rare remnant of the lost originals. Identical inscriptions also appear on the flanks of the minbar Jaqmaq commissioned for Sultan Barquq's complex (786-88 AH / 1384-86 CE) on al-Muʿizz Street. Although Jaqmaq was not known for extensive or innovative artistic patronage, such commissions, often in the context of restoration or renewal, appear to have served as a means of asserting personal piety and architectural stewardship rather than visual ambition.

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